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LEARNER GUIDE

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Claude Cowork Masterclass

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3.0	16 September 2026	Rebuilt on the Claude Style design shared with the Claude Code Masterclass, reusing its Claude product family and AI evolution slides. Replaced the eight finance labs with three topics — Cowork Fundamentals (Live Artefacts), Tools and Skills (Google Drive and Gmail connectors plus a reusable daily-brief automation) and Claude Projects (assembling everything into one shared workspace) — delivered as six coherent labs on one fictitious company, Meridian Capital Partners Pte Ltd. Ready-to-paste prompts added to the slides, Learner Guide and labs, and each lab is now issued in both Markdown and PDF.	Dr. Alfred Ang

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Introduction.....	4
Course Learning Outcomes.....	4
Before You Start — Preparation.....	4
Topic 01 — Claude Cowork Fundamentals.....	5
Lab 1 — Your First Live Artefact.....	5
Lab 2 — The Meridian Sales Dashboard.....	7
Topic 02 — Tools and Skills.....	8
Lab 3 — Connect Google Drive.....	9
Lab 4 — Refresh the Dashboard and Send the Summary.....	10
Lab 5 — Build a /daily-brief Skill.....	12
Topic 03 — Claude Projects.....	13
Lab 6 — Build the Meridian Claude Project.....	14
Wrap-Up.....	16
Next Steps.....	16
Glossary.....	16

Introduction

Claude Cowork is the desktop agent in the Claude family built for people who work with files and reports rather than code. This course teaches it through one continuous scenario: you are on the finance team at Meridian Capital Partners Pte Ltd, and over six labs you build a live sales dashboard, connect it to the firm's data in Google Drive, deliver an approved summary by Gmail, wrap that routine into a reusable daily-brief skill, and finish by gathering everything into one Claude Project your whole team can work from.

Meridian Capital Partners is a fictitious Singapore-based investment and advisory firm with four revenue desks — Advisory, Asset Management, Private Credit and Corporate Finance. All figures, clients, staff and documents in this course are synthetic and used for training only.

Course Learning Outcomes

- LO1: Set up Claude and the Cowork desktop workspace, and explain where Cowork fits in the Claude product family.
- LO2: Build, save and download a Live Artefact, including an interactive sales dashboard from supplied data.
- LO3: Connect the Google Drive connector so Claude can read finance data held outside the chat.
- LO4: Refresh a Live Artefact from connected data and send an approved summary with the Gmail connector.
- LO5: Write an Agent Skill that runs a repeatable routine across your connected tools on one command.
- LO6: Assemble a Claude Project that holds the data, instructions, skill and dashboard as one reusable team workspace.

Before You Start — Preparation

What you need

- A laptop (Mac or Windows) with the Claude desktop app installed from claude.ai/download.
- A Claude account on a paid plan — Cowork and Live Artefacts are paid-plan desktop features.
- A Google account with Google Drive and Gmail, used for the connector labs.
- The lab folder for this course, copied to your machine.

Verify your setup

Open the Claude desktop app, sign in, and confirm you can see Cowork in the sidebar. Ask Claude to build a small test artefact and check it appears in the preview pane beside the chat. If it does, your setup is ready.

Conventions used in every lab

- Prompts shown in a bordered box are meant to be copied into Claude as they are.
- Placeholders such as <YOUR FOLDER> are replaced with your own values.
- All Meridian Capital data is synthetic; use only the supplied mock data.
- Every lab ends with a check step — confirm the output before moving on.

Topic 01 — Claude Cowork Fundamentals

The Claude family · Cowork setup · Live Artefacts · save & download

Key concepts

- Claude CoworkThe desktop agent that works on your files and tasks — built for non-developers, not coders.
- Live ArtefactsInteractive tools that persist in your workspace and refresh their data when reopened.
- Desktop, not browserLive Artefacts and local file access need the Claude desktop app on a paid plan.
- Describe, don't codeYou describe the tool you want in plain English; Claude writes and runs the code.
- Save to the sidebarA saved artefact is reopenable and reusable — it is not lost in the chat history.
- Download to shareExport the artefact so it can be filed, attached or handed to someone without Claude.

Lab 1 — Your First Live Artefact

Learning outcome: set up the Cowork workspace and build, save and download a Live Artefact.

Goal: You have just joined the finance team at Meridian Capital Partners. Before touching the firm's numbers, you get Claude Cowork working and build a small Live Artefact so you can see how an artefact differs from a chat answer — it persists, it is interactive, and you can save and download it.

What you'll build

A saved, downloaded Live Artefact — a working Meridian FX converter. (Tools: Claude desktop app, Claude Cowork, Live Artefacts.)

The prompt

Copy the block below into Claude exactly as it is.

PROMPT — copy into Claude

Build me a Live Artefact: a currency converter for Meridian Capital Partners.

Requirements:

- Convert between SGD, USD, EUR and GBP.
- Use these fixed demo rates from SGD: USD 0.74, EUR 0.68, GBP 0.58.
- One amount box, a from-currency and a to-currency selector, and a large result.
- Show the rate used underneath the result.
- Clean, professional finance styling. Label it "Meridian Capital Partners".

Make it interactive so I can change the amount and see the result update.

Note: Rates are fixed demo values so the lab gives the same answer for everyone.

Step-by-step

1. Open the Claude desktop app and sign in with your paid-plan account.

Live Artefacts and local file access are desktop features – the browser version does not support them.

2. Choose Cowork in the sidebar to open the agent workspace rather than a plain chat.

Cowork gives Claude a workspace it can act in, instead of only answering in the conversation.

3. Paste the lab prompt into the composer and send it.

Claude writes the code and renders the converter in the preview pane beside the chat.

4. Try the converter: change the amount and switch the currencies.

This is what makes it an artefact rather than an answer – you can interact with it.

5. Ask for one refinement in plain English, for example: Add a thousands separator to the result.

Refining by conversation is the normal way to work – you never edit the code yourself.

6. Save the artefact so it appears in your sidebar.

A saved artefact persists as a reusable tool; an unsaved one scrolls away with the chat.

7. Download a copy of the artefact to your lab folder.

Downloading gives you a file you can keep, attach or hand to someone without Claude.

Test it

Converting S\$10,000 to USD shows US\$7,400. The artefact appears in your sidebar after saving, still works when you reopen it, and a downloaded copy is in your lab folder.

Note: Full commands and screenshots are in labs/lab-01-*.md. Use only the supplied mock data and your own test accounts. Never put real client, personal or confidential data into a training exercise, and send lab emails to yourself rather than to a real recipient.

Lab 2 — The Meridian Sales Dashboard

Learning outcome: turn supplied finance data into an interactive Live Artefact dashboard.

Goal: Meridian's head of finance wants to see how the four revenue desks performed this year without opening a spreadsheet. You take the supplied sales data and build it into a Live Artefact dashboard — KPI tiles, a trend chart and a desk breakdown — then save it. This dashboard is the artefact every later lab builds on.

What you'll build

A saved Live Artefact dashboard showing Meridian's FY2026 revenue by desk. (Tools: Claude Cowork, Live Artefacts, local files.)

The prompt

Copy the block below into Claude exactly as it is.

PROMPT — copy into Claude

Using the attached meridian-sales-fy2026.csv, build me a Live Artefact: an interactive sales dashboard for Meridian Capital Partners.

Include:

- KPI tiles: total revenue, total deals, average deal size, best desk.
- A monthly revenue trend chart for the full year.
- A breakdown of revenue by desk (Advisory, Asset Management, Private Credit, Corporate Finance).
- A filter to show one desk at a time or all desks.

Format all money as Singapore dollars with thousands separators.
Use a clean, professional finance layout. Title it
"Meridian Capital Partners – FY2026 Revenue".

Note: Attach the CSV from your lab's mock-data folder before sending the prompt.

Step-by-step

1. Open the lab folder and look at meridian-sales-fy2026.csv so you know what the data holds.

Always know your source before you ask Claude to summarise it – that is how you spot a wrong figure later.

2. Start a Cowork session and attach the CSV, or point Claude at the lab folder.

Scope Claude to the one folder for this task rather than your whole drive.

3. Paste the lab prompt and send it.

Claude reads the file, works out the totals and builds the dashboard in the preview pane.

4. Check the KPI tiles against the CSV: total revenue should be S\$24,850,000 across 214 deals.

This is the verification habit – read the artefact's numbers back against the source.

5. Use the desk filter to view Advisory on its own, then return to all desks.

Interactivity is the point of a Live Artefact: the reader explores instead of asking you for another cut.

6. Refine the layout in plain English, for example: Move the KPI tiles above the chart.

Keep refining by conversation until the dashboard reads the way you want it to.

7. Save the dashboard to your sidebar with a clear name, then download a copy.

You will reopen this same artefact in Lab 4 and rebrand it in Lab 6.

Test it

The dashboard shows total revenue S\$24,850,000 and 214 deals, Advisory is the best desk at S\$8,420,000, the desk filter changes the chart, and the artefact reopens from your sidebar after you close it.

Note: Full commands and screenshots are in labs/lab-02-*.md. Use only the supplied mock data and your own test accounts. Never put real client, personal or confidential data into a training exercise, and send lab emails to yourself rather than to a real recipient.

Topic 02 — Tools and Skills

Google Drive · Gmail · Agent Skills · a reusable /daily-brief automation

Key concepts

- Connectors Toggle Gmail, Calendar and Drive on from the + menu so Claude can reach data outside the chat.

- Google Drive Claude reads Sheets, Docs, Slides and PDFs from Drive, and can upload files back to a folder.
- Scope the folder Point Claude at one Drive folder for the task — not your whole Drive.
- Gmail Claude drafts, sends, replies and labels — sending asks for explicit approval by default.
- Agent Skills A folder of instructions Claude loads on demand, so a task runs the same way every time.
- Skills use tools A skill can drive the connectors for you — one command that checks Drive and Gmail and reports back.

Lab 3 — Connect Google Drive

Learning outcome: enable the Google Drive connector and read finance data held outside the chat.

Goal: Meridian's finance data does not live on your laptop — it sits in a shared Google Drive folder. You upload the firm's wider finance files to Drive, enable the Google Drive connector, and confirm Claude can read them without you attaching anything by hand.

What you'll build

A working Google Drive connection scoped to the Meridian finance folder. (Tools: Claude Cowork, Google Drive connector.)

The prompt

Copy the block below into Claude exactly as it is.

PROMPT — copy into Claude

Using the Google Drive connector, open the folder "Meridian Finance" in my Drive and tell me what you find.

For each file, give me:

- The file name and what kind of data it holds.
- The period it covers.
- The three figures you would use in a quarterly revenue summary.

Do not change, move or delete anything – read only.

List anything that looks inconsistent between the files.

Note: Claude asks for approval before it moves, shares or deletes a Drive file.

Step-by-step

1. Upload the lab's mock-data files to a new Google Drive folder named Meridian Finance.

The lab supplies the quarterly workbook, the desk targets and the client list as mock data.

2. In Claude, click the plus sign in the composer and hover over Connectors.

This is where you turn individual connectors on and off for your account.

3. Toggle Google Drive on and sign in to your Google account.

On a Team or Enterprise plan an owner must enable connectors for the organisation first.

4. Approve the permissions Google asks for.

Approve only what you are willing to let Claude reach – you can revoke access later.

5. Paste the lab prompt so Claude reads the Meridian Finance folder.

Naming the folder scopes the task; Claude does not need access to your whole Drive.

6. Compare Claude's file summary against what you actually uploaded.

Confirm it found every file and read the right periods before you rely on it.

7. Note any inconsistency Claude reports between the files.

The Q4 Advisory target deliberately disagrees between two files – a real check.

Test it

Claude lists all three Meridian Finance files with their periods, reports FY2026 revenue of S\$24,850,000, and flags that the Q4 Advisory target disagrees between the two files — S\$2,320,000 in the targets file against S\$2,410,000 in the workbook. Nothing in Drive has been changed.

Note: Full commands and screenshots are in labs/lab-03-*.md. Use only the supplied mock data and your own test accounts. Never put real client, personal or confidential data into a training exercise, and send lab emails to yourself rather than to a real recipient.

Lab 4 — Refresh the Dashboard and Send the Summary

Learning outcome: update the Live Artefact from connected data and deliver an approved summary by Gmail.

Goal: Quarter end has arrived. You refresh the dashboard you built in Lab 2 using the data Claude now reads from Drive, then have it draft a quarterly summary email to the head of finance. You read the draft against the figures and approve it before a single message leaves your outbox.

What you'll build

An updated dashboard plus an approved quarterly summary email sent to yourself. (Tools: Claude Cowork, Live Artefacts, Google Drive connector, Gmail connector.)

The prompt

Copy the block below into Claude exactly as it is.

PROMPT — copy into Claude

Two tasks, in order.

1. Open my saved "Meridian Capital Partners – FY2026 Revenue" dashboard and update it from the Meridian Finance folder in Google Drive. Add a Q4 column to the desk breakdown and show each desk's actual against its target.
2. Then draft an email to <YOUR OWN ADDRESS> with the subject "Meridian FY2026 – Q4 revenue summary". In the body:
 - Total FY2026 revenue and the Q4 figure.
 - Each desk's Q4 actual against target, best and worst first.
 - Two sentences explaining the largest variance.
 - A closing line noting the Q4 Advisory target discrepancy.

Show me the draft. Do not send it until I approve it.

Note: Replace <YOUR OWN ADDRESS> with your own email — never a real client's.

Step-by-step

1. Reopen the dashboard you saved in Lab 2 from your sidebar.

You are extending the artefact you already built, not starting a new one.

2. Enable the Gmail connector from the plus menu, alongside Google Drive.

Turn on only the connectors this task needs.

3. Paste the lab prompt, replacing the placeholder with your own email address.

Class exercises always go to a test recipient – yourself.

4. Watch Claude refresh the dashboard from Drive and add the Q4 target comparison.

The data comes from the connector now; you are not attaching files by hand.

5. Check the refreshed dashboard: Q4 revenue should be S\$6,980,000 across the four desks.

Verify the artefact before you let it feed an email to your head of finance.

6. Read the drafted email in full and compare every figure against the dashboard.

Claude asks for explicit approval before sending – this is the moment to use it.

7. Approve the send, then confirm the message arrived in your own inbox.

Approve only once the figures match; if anything is wrong, ask for a correction first.

Test it

The dashboard shows a Q4 column with actual against target per desk and Q4 revenue of S\$6,980,000. The email arrives in your own inbox with the correct totals and a closing note about the Advisory target discrepancy.

Note: Full commands and screenshots are in labs/lab-04-*.md. Use only the supplied mock data and your own test accounts. Never put real client, personal or confidential data into a training exercise, and send lab emails to yourself rather than to a real recipient.

Lab 5 — Build a /daily-brief Skill

Learning outcome: write an Agent Skill that runs a repeatable routine across your connected tools.

Goal: Labs 3 and 4 showed what the connectors can do — but you had to describe the whole routine each time. Now you capture it once as an Agent Skill. Every morning you type one command and Claude checks Drive and Gmail and briefs you on where Meridian's reporting stands, in the same format every day.

What you'll build

A daily-brief Agent Skill you can run by name each morning. (Tools: Claude Cowork, Agent Skills, Google Drive connector, Gmail connector.)

The prompt

Copy the block below into Claude exactly as it is.

PROMPT — copy into Claude

I want to create an automation. I want this to be a daily briefing automation for my finance work at Meridian Capital Partners.

The goal: every morning when I come into Claude, I type /daily-brief and it runs the routine and catches me up on everything:

- What changed in the Meridian Finance folder on Google Drive since yesterday?
- Which desks are behind their quarterly target right now?
- What finance emails do I need to respond to today?

I want fallbacks. If there is nothing in a section, say so plainly – "No new files since yesterday" – rather than padding it out. End with one line on what most needs my attention, or "Nothing urgent – have a good day" if there is nothing.

Keep all money in Singapore dollars with thousands separators. Draft only – never send an email as part of this routine.

Save this as a skill I can reuse, and show me the finished SKILL.md.

Note: The description line is what tells Claude when to load the skill — keep it specific.

Step-by-step

1. Make sure the Drive and Gmail connectors from Labs 3 and 4 are still enabled.

The skill drives those connectors, so it can only work if they are on.

2. Paste the lab prompt into Cowork.

You are describing the routine once; Claude writes it into the skill structure.

3. Read the SKILL.md Claude produces, starting with the description line.

The description is how Claude decides whether to load the skill for a future task.

4. Check each of the three sections is there, with its fallback wording.

The fallbacks are what stop the routine inventing filler on a quiet morning.

5. Confirm the skill drafts only and never sends — ask for a correction if not.

A routine that runs unattended must not be able to send mail on its own.

6. Save the skill, then run it by name to see the briefing.

This is the payoff: one command instead of re-describing the whole routine.

7. Run it a second time and confirm the format is identical.

Consistency is the point of a skill – the same structure every single run.

Test it

Running the skill produces a briefing with all three sections — Drive changes, desks behind target, emails needing a reply — using the plain fallback wording where a section is empty, ending with a single attention line, with all money in SGD and no email sent.

Note: Full commands and screenshots are in labs/lab-05-*.md. Use only the supplied mock data and your own test accounts. Never put real client, personal or confidential data into a training exercise, and send lab emails to yourself rather than to a real recipient.

Topic 03 — Claude Projects

Bringing it together · project knowledge · reusable workspace for the team

Key concepts

- A Claude ProjectA dedicated place for ongoing work, where context builds over time instead of resetting each chat.

- Backed by a folder In Cowork the files and instructions live in a real folder on your computer — you can still open them yourself.
- Three ways to start Start from scratch, import a project you made in Chat, or point Claude at a folder you already work from.
- Project instructions Standing rules for this body of work — house style, SGD formatting, check before sending.
- Everything in one place The finance data, the brand rules, your daily-brief skill and the dashboard, together.
- Share the folder A colleague opens the same project and inherits the data, rules and tools you set up.

Lab 6 — Build the Meridian Claude Project

Learning outcome: assemble the data, instructions, skill and dashboard into one reusable Project.

Goal: Everything you have built so far lives in separate places — a dashboard in your sidebar, files in Drive, a skill, and rules you have been restating by hand. In this final lab you gather them into one Cowork Project: a dedicated folder on your computer where context builds over time, and which a colleague can open and be immediately productive in.

What you'll build

A Meridian Finance Reporting project holding the data, instructions, skill and dashboard. (Tools: Claude Cowork, Projects, Agent Skills, Live Artefacts, Google Drive connector.)

The prompt

Copy the block below into Claude exactly as it is.

PROMPT — copy into Claude

This project is Meridian Finance Reporting. Write the project instructions that should apply to every task I run in here:

- We are the finance team at Meridian Capital Partners Pte Ltd. Our four revenue desks are Advisory, Asset Management, Private Credit and Corporate Finance.
- All money in Singapore dollars, thousands separators, no decimals.
- Variances show both the absolute figure and the percentage.
- Every report carries the title "Meridian Capital Partners" and the reporting period, and the footer "internal use only".
- Headings in a serif font, body text in a clean sans-serif.
- Tone: factual and concise. No marketing language.
- Always show me a draft before sending anything. Never send email without my explicit approval.
- The finance data in this project folder is the source of truth.

Write these as clear project instructions, then confirm what you will now do differently in every chat in this project.

Note: Project instructions apply to every chat in the project — you stop restating them.

Step-by-step

1. In Cowork, choose New project, then Start from scratch.

The other two routes on that screen are Import a project (bring one over from Chat) and Use an existing folder (point Claude at a folder you already work from).

2. In the Start a new project dialog, type the Name: Meridian Finance Reporting.

The dialog has four fields – Name, Instructions, Add files and Choose project location.

3. Paste the lab prompt's rules into the Instructions box.

These are the standing rules – house style, SGD formatting and the approval habit – applied to every chat in the project.

4. Under Add files, drop in the Meridian finance data and the brand guidelines.

Adding them once means no chat in this project has to re-attach them.

5. Set Choose project location to where you want the folder to live, then click Create.

A Cowork project is backed by a real folder on your computer – you can open the files yourself at any time.

6. Add the daily-brief skill from Lab 5 to the project.

The routine now travels with the project, so anyone working in it can run it.

7. Open the project folder on your computer and confirm the files are really there.

This is what distinguishes a Cowork project – the instructions and files are a folder you own, not something locked inside the app.

8. Save the FY2026 dashboard into the project so it sits with the data it reports on.

The artefact, its data and its rules finally live in one place.

9. Start a fresh chat in the project and ask for a one-paragraph Q4 summary.

Test the payoff: no files attached, no rules restated, and the output already follows the house style.

10. Confirm the folder holds the data, instructions, skill and dashboard, ready to share.

Handing a colleague this folder hands them the whole working setup.

Test it

A Meridian Finance Reporting project exists, backed by a folder containing the finance data and brand guidelines, with project instructions set, the daily-brief skill available and

the dashboard saved. A brand-new chat in the project produces a Q4 summary in SGD with the correct header and footer without you attaching a file or restating a single rule.

Note: Full commands and screenshots are in labs/lab-06-*.md. Use only the supplied mock data and your own test accounts. Never put real client, personal or confidential data into a training exercise, and send lab emails to yourself rather than to a real recipient.

Wrap-Up

Across six labs you took one finance scenario from a blank workspace to a branded, connected, reusable dashboard.

What you built

- A Live Artefact sales dashboard for Meridian Capital, saved and downloaded.
- A Google Drive connection that feeds the dashboard from the firm's finance data.
- An approved Gmail summary of the quarter, sent to a test recipient.
- A daily-brief Agent Skill that runs the whole morning routine on one command.
- A Meridian Finance Reporting Project holding the data, instructions, skill and dashboard.

The habit to keep

- Describe the outcome, let Claude build it, then check the figures yourself.
- Scope every connector to the one folder or mailbox the task needs.
- Approve every outgoing message against the source data before it is sent.
- Write a routine down once as a skill instead of retyping it every time.
- Keep the work in a Project so context builds instead of resetting each chat.

Next Steps

- First pass: complete every lab yourself, following the steps in each lab file.
- Second pass: redo the labs from memory until the workflow is automatic.
- Apply the techniques to a real process or project in your own organisation.
- Review each lab's detailed steps in this guide and re-run the labs on your own.

Glossary

- **Agent Skill** — A folder containing a SKILL.md of instructions that Claude loads on demand when the task matches its description.

- **Artefact** — A self-contained output Claude builds — a document, dashboard or tool — shown beside the chat rather than inside it.
- **Claude Cowork** — The desktop agent for non-developers that works on your files, folders and connected apps.
- **Connector** — An integration that lets Claude reach an outside service such as Google Drive, Gmail or Calendar.
- **Live Artefact** — An artefact that persists in your workspace, keeps its state, and refreshes its data when reopened.
- **MCP** — Model Context Protocol — the open standard connectors use to expose tools and data to Claude.
- **SKILL.md** — The Markdown file at the heart of an Agent Skill: name, description and instructions.